



**OMAR ABDULLAH, THE NEW
CHIEF MINISTER OF JAMMU
AND KASHMIR**

Action Plan

laid out the Indian bottomline which is that no formal change of existing borders would be acceptable. Both the countries have agreed that the borders between the two Kashmirs must be softened. India needs to tackle the Kashmir problem on two fronts: first, to deal with Pakistan on the issue, and second, to resolve the state's autonomy problems.

The emergence of a new civilian government in Pakistan has brought a hiatus of sorts. The Mumbai massacre has created its own problems. The original intention was to situate the Kashmir border formula within a larger opening up of the India-Pakistan border as a consequence of the acceptance of a South Asian Free Trade Area. But while there has been significant growth of trade, progress in softening the border in Kashmir, and some opening up of blocked transport corridors in Punjab and Rajasthan, there has been little movement towards SAFTA.

When Jammu and Kashmir acceded to the Indian Union, it offered to put defence, foreign affairs and communications into the hands of the Centre. Subsequently these issues were spelt out in Article 370 of the

TAKE significant steps towards Kashmiri autonomy.

INVOLVE civil society, especially women, in economic initiatives.

CONVINCE the world that a non-communal and non-sectarian solution is in the best interests of Jammu and Kashmir.

KEEP up dialogue with Pakistan with a view to eliminate the infrastructure of cross-border terrorism and to appear as a reasonable actor in the international stage.

CONTAIN and defeat the terrorist threat with maintenance of adequate security.

OFFER an amnesty to Kashmiri-origin militants.

CREATE a truth commission for missing persons.

SOFTEN the border; actively engage people of PoK and the northern areas.

RECOGNISE Pakistan's control of 'Azad' Kashmir in return for it accepting LoC as the permanent border.

Indian Constitution. In 1952, a Delhi Agreement signed between the Government of India and that of Jammu and Kashmir spelt these out in some detail. Since then, however, the state's special status and autonomy were undermined systematically by the Union government. In 1994, the then Prime Minister P.V. Narasimha Rao had declared that the "sky is the limit" as to the amount of autonomy India could give to the people of the state. But when in July 2000 the elected government sent the report of the state autonomy commission recommending full autonomy to the state except in the areas of finance, defence and foreign affairs, the Union government shot it down.

India should not fear to offer Kashmir a degree of autonomy that would evolve the Valley to maintain its 'Kashmiriyat.' With Pakistan, while it should not negotiate out of fear, it should not fear to negotiate a way out of the Kashmir impasse without compromising on India's sovereignty and territorial integrity.